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Sports Desk

By JOE DIETZ

Andy Cohen's night of glory

As this is written, Gene Mauch, the new manager of the fearsome Phillies, had just arrived in North Philadelphia from Florida to take over the reins that Eddie Sawyer tossed disgustedly over the front of the backboard Thursday morning.

Some of his first words sounded ominous so far as Andy Cohen, Dick Carter and Ken Sylvestri are concerned. They were coaches under Sawyer and the young Mr. Mauch indicated that he had not discussed the matter of a supporting cast yet with General Manager John Quinn.

On the optimistic side so far as Cohen, Carter and Sylvestri are concerned is Mauch's commendable admission that "coaches are important." But he added with something of foreboding in his voice, that every manager has the inherent right to choose his own coaching staff.

We are not concerned here with Carter or Sylvestri. So far as we know they are fine and capable tutors. Our real interest is mostly in Cohen. He is our very own former Newark boy, Heaven's gift to the yearning Israelites who for many years roamed the baseball deserts in search of a hero they could call their own.

Many, many years ago they found him in Andy Cohen. He came up to the Giants from Buffalo in 1928. He was heralded as the Jewish star John McGraw was searching for to hypo the gate—in competition with Babe Ruth of the Yankees.

Andy off to flying start

That first day against the Boston Braves, Andy got two singles and a double.

"Bob Smith was pitching for the Braves," Cohen recalled Thursday night before the Phils took on another Braves team from Milwaukee with Cohen manager pro-tem pending the arrival of Mauch.

"They walked George Harper, an outfielder, to get to me and I hit my double. It just missed being a home run in left field. We won by a couple of runs. It was a big thrill for me."

Andy's debut created quite a commotion. Flaming headlines spoke of Cohen as another Rogers Hornsby, a pretty good second baseman for the Braves whom Cohen had replaced with the Giants.

"Hornsby didn't do much that day," Andy said. "That's what started it."

"I got off ahead of him. Then I kept up with him for about four or five weeks. I was hitting .359 or .375. And then Hornsby kept going up and I went the other way. He not only beat me, he beat everybody. He hit .378 and I hit .274."

The social Andy did OK

As some oldtimers may recall, Cohen's life in the majors was meteoric and brief. It wasn't exactly the pace on the greensward that killed him off so quickly. It was the social pace. Andy loved people and loved to be with people. He never missed a dinner or a bar mitzvah. His people loved him and he loved his people.

Result: He was sold to Newark after the 1929 season. Fake New York friends deserted him. But he made new ones in Newark. He was always surrounded by admirers at the Hotel Riviera, now the personal property of the benevolent Father Divine.

It was at the Riviera that Cohen met his most unstinting admirer, a 15-year-old kid named Herzl Rabinowitz. But nobody called him that. He was just "Hoxie." He is now the owner of a men's shop in Branford Pl., a guy whose deep affection and admiration kept him in touch with Andy Cohen through the long years.

"I happened to be at the Riviera one day ogling the Buffalo ballplayers who were staying there," Hoxie recalls. "One of the players looked at my red hair and asked me if I was looking for Cohen. I don't know who Cohen is but I say sure."

"Andy and the others made me their bat boy and I guess I brought them luck. They won four straight after losing about 12 and that was it."

"I ran away from home when Buffalo left town to be their bat boy. They gave me a uniform and \$12 a week plus expenses, but the cops put an end to that. I was only 15½ and they thought I should be in school."

"I became visiting team batboy at Ruppert Stadium and was still on the job after the Giants sold Andy to the Bears. He couldn't stand rid of me. I was with him day and night. He was my idol and the other guys used to call me 'Little Andy Cohen.'"

Dandy Andy 'regular'

What attracted him to Andy?

"He was a regular guy, never brushed off the kids like the other players. He tried to teach me how to play baseball and every Christmas he'd send me a glove or something as a present. He was always telling me what to do—like a father—that I shouldn't hang around with the wrong people and things like that."

"I was in Philly the other night when he made his one-night debut as the first Jewish manager in major league baseball history. Man, what he didn't do to that Chuck Dressen in Milwaukee in that 10th inning when the Phils won it, 5-4. He sure picked the right guys to bat."

Cohen was out of baseball last year for the first time in over 30 years when he did public relations work for a beer outfit in El Paso where he lives with his wife and three kids.

"John Quinn called me last winter and asked me if I wanted to coach in Philadelphia. Well, I love baseball and I said yes and here I am. What did I tell the players before the game—like they should win this one for Cohen? Now, I just told them I had been trying for 30 years to get in this spot and to go out and do their best as they did."

If Gene Mauch doesn't keep this able and likable guy on as coach, a lot of Philadelphians are going to be mad about it. Especially after Thursday night.